economy—the declining wages and rising education and health care costs, Aschoff said. The average person hadn't been using credit or loans before. Suddenly they became ubiquitous.

So how can we avoid the big banks and their legalized exploitation? One good alternative to using a bank is joining a credit union. According to MyCreditUnion.gov, a credit union is a nonprofit money exchange set up by an employer, location, family, church, labor union, and many other types of groups. Membership to a credit union can cost anywhere from $5 to $25, and the website allows you to find one near you. In general, a credit union charges you less than a bank will in annual fees. Some reimburse you for ATM fees so you're not losing money because of a lack of available ATMs.

But the big draw is this: 98 million Americans use credit unions because they are run more democratically than banks. (Members get votes on who sits on the union's board of directors, for example.) There are all different kinds of credit unions, including Alliant, Connexus, First Tech, and Golden 1 Credit Union, and each has its own specialty and qualifications. Some are better for businesses, and some are better for students. It depends on what you are looking for, so think about what suits your banking needs and do your research.

Payday lenders are yet another option besides a bank or a credit union, and Servon is a big fan of these. But her love for payday lenders is extremely rare, and her opinion may be somewhat informed by the time she spent working at one in the Bronx while researching her book. The dominant perception is that they take advantage of people. In fact, John Oliver ripped into payday loan centers in a 2014 segment on his show *Last Week Tonight* called "Predatory Lending." Here's a recap of what I learned from it.

A "payday loan" is a loan attained quickly and easily using what's called a payday lender (at a check cashing or payday loan store or online) to cover an "unexpected expense." Also called cash advances, payday loans are meant to be short term. Oliver reported that one in twenty households have taken a payday loan out at some point. It's a $9 billion industry, even as they remain illegal in some states, including Connecticut, Maryland, Vermont, and West Virginia. The problem with payday loans is that they take advantage of vulnerable people who are sometimes unable to pay the loan off on their next "payday" and then